United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

Key concepts in the Convention

Unit 3 PowerPoint presentation

UNESCO
Intangible Cultural Heritage Section

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Word cloud of the Convention

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In this presentation …

More about the Convention:

- A flexible instrument
- ‘Anchoring the Convention’

Terms to be discussed:

- Intangible heritage; elements
- Communities, groups, individuals
- Safeguarding

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The Convention – a flexible instrument

- Few obligations
- Few definitions
- Open definitions
- Non-exhaustive classifications (domains of ICH, safeguarding measures)
- No official glossary

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‘Anchoring the Convention’ at the country level

The term ‘ICH’ translated:

- *Turathi za tamaduni zisizogusika* (Kiswahili)
- *Di sản văn hóa phi vật thể* (Vietnamese for ‘heritage – cultural, not [*phi*] tangible’)
- *Nematerialno kulturno nasledstvo* (Bulgarian for ‘non-material cultural heritage’)
- *Mukei* (Japanese for ‘not having form’)
- *Vaimne kultuuripärand* (Estonian)
- *Patrimônio cultural imaterial* (Portuguese)

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INTANGIBLE CULTURAL HERITAGE

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The Convention's definition of intangible heritage (1)

Article 2.1:

For the purposes of the Convention, the 'Intangible Cultural Heritage' means the practices, representations, expressions, knowledge, skills

– as well as the instruments, objects, artefacts and cultural spaces associated therewith –

that communities, groups and, in some cases, individuals recognize as part of their cultural heritage.

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The Convention's definition of intangible heritage (2)

Article 2.1 continues:

This intangible cultural heritage, transmitted from generation to generation, is constantly recreated by communities and groups in response to their environment, their interaction with nature and their history, and provides them with a sense of identity and continuity, thus promoting respect for cultural diversity and human creativity.

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The Convention's definition of intangible heritage (3)

Article 2.1 further:

For the purposes of this Convention, consideration will be given solely to such intangible cultural heritage as is compatible with existing international human rights instruments, as well as with the requirements of mutual respect among communities, groups and individuals,

and of sustainable development.

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Intangible heritage domains

Article 2.2

(a) oral traditions and expressions, including language as a vehicle of the intangible cultural heritage;

(b) performing arts;

(c) social practices, rituals and festive events;

(d) knowledge and practices concerning nature and the universe;

(e) traditional craftsmanship.

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Zema liturgical music (Ethiopia)

A form of liturgical music unique to Orthodox Christian Ethiopia, Zema is performed at various religious ceremonies such as the monthly celebration of Gabra Manfas Qedus, a local saint.

While the singers wear simple white robes, the priests (pictured here in front of Saris Abo Church in Addis Ababa) wear sumptuous garments and carry covered icons on their heads.

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Hudhud chants of the Ifugao (the Philippines)

Women chanting in the fields
© 2008 by J. Uñalivia/NCCA-IHC

Well known for their rice terraces and extensive knowledge of rice cultivation, the Ifugao perform the Hudhud chants during the sowing and harvest seasons and at funeral wakes.

The chants, which are transmitted orally, concern ancestral heroes, customary law, traditional practices and religious beliefs.

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Vanuatu sand drawings

© Vanuatu National Cultural Council

Sand drawing is a multifunctional ‘writing’ produced on the ground, in sand, volcanic ash or clay, using one finger to draw a graceful, often symmetrical composition of geometric patterns.

It serves as a means of communication among the members of about eighty ethnolinguistic groups in Vanuatu.

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COMMUNITIES, GROUPS AND INDIVIDUALS

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Defining the community concerned

Ramman: religious festival and ritual theatre of the Garhwal Himalayas, India
© IGNCA, Ministry of Culture, India

Under the Convention, ‘communities, groups and individuals concerned’ means those who participate in the practice or transmission of the ICH element, and consider it to be part of their cultural heritage.

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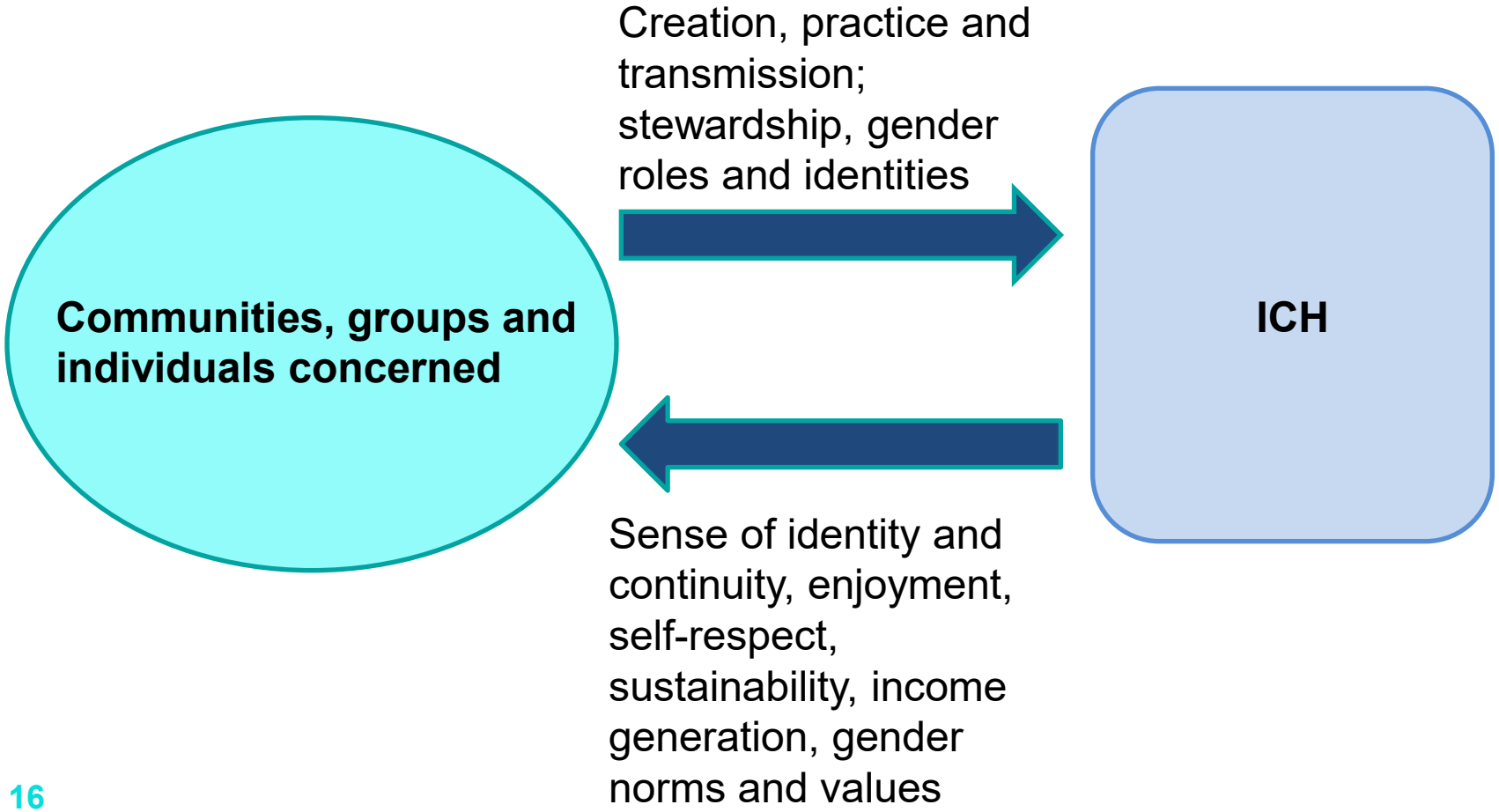
Relationship between an element and the group/community concerned



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SAFEGUARDING

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Safeguarding concepts

© West Zone Cultural Centre, Udajpur, Rajasthan

- **Safeguarding** means ensuring the **viability** of ICH (Article 2.3)
- **Threats** to viability are current problems hampering the enactment and transmission of the element
- **Risks** are anticipated problems

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Key safeguarding measures

Inventorying

Presenting information on ICH elements in a systematic way

Awareness-raising

Encouraging people to understand and appreciate ICH

Revitalization

Strengthening of endangered ICH practices

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More safeguarding measures

- Documentation, research
- Identification, definition
- Preservation, protection
- Promotion, enhancement
- Transmission, e.g. through education

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Role of communities in safeguarding

Communities, groups and individuals

Engage in …

- Transmission
- Enactment of ICH

and may do ...

- Identification
- Inventorying
- Documentation
- Research
- Revitalization
- Ensuring access to places and materials
- Transmission through education
- Raising awareness

Note: community participation is needed in all these activities

…with help from other agencies if needed

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In conclusion

- Intangible cultural heritage is living heritage
- Always changing
- Defined, recognized, practised and transmitted by the people (‘communities, groups and individuals’) who are the stewards of that heritage
- Safeguarding involves assisting communities to continue practising, managing and transmitting their ICH
- ‘Communities, groups and individuals’ not defined under the Convention
- States Parties need to involve communities, groups and individuals in safeguarding their ICH, paying due attention to the mutual relationship between gender relations and ICH.

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